MSC *ELSA 3*

FLAG: Liberia

ROUTE: Vizhinjam to Kochi

MISHAP: Sank off Thottappally (Alappuzha) coast

DATE: May 25

CARGO: 643 containers; including 13 with hazardous cargo, like plastic nurdles, besides 367 tonnes of highly inflammable furnace oil and 84 tonnes of diesel

plastic manufacturing—scattered across the water, a synthetic blizzard in the middle of fish-breeding season.

If Kerala's coast was still catching its breath, the sea had other plans. On June 9, the Singapore-registered MV *Wan Hai 503*, a floating warehouse of 650 containers, erupted in flames and explosions further north, 43 nautical miles off the Azhikkal coast. The ship, bound from Colombo to Mumbai, had 22 crew members. Four are missing and two of the 18 rescued have severe burns. Five coast guard ships and the navy's INS *Surat* were deployed, but the fire, fed by volatile cargo—nitrocellulose, benzophenone, magnesium, turpentine, ethanol—proved a stubborn adversary. Adding to the peril, the vessel's 2,000 tonnes of marine oil and 240 tonnes of diesel sit precariously close to 32 tonnes of alcohol, making for a lethally inflammable cocktail. "Our priority is to carry out salvage operations and minimise the oil spill. The task is very challenging," says Commander Atul Pillai, defence PRO for Kerala and Lakshadweep.

AFTER THE WRECK

Back in Kochi, the bureaucratic machinery has lurched into motion. Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan has set up two high-level committees—one at the state level and another at the district level—to coordinate relief and environmental assessments. "The state has taken all necessary precautions [to contain] maritime casualties and is conducting environmental and social impact studies on the Kerala coast," says chief secretary A. Jayathilak. "Now, our priority is to assess [immediate] losses and extend relief to the affected coastal communities." The state, after some foot-dragging, has also filed a criminal case against Mediterranean Shipping Company, the Geneva-headquartered operator of the MSC *Elsa 3*.

With the southwest monsoon back at orange alert levels and a statewide trawling ban in effect since June 10, the dual disasters have dealt a double blow to Kerala's 1.13 million-strong fishing community. "These shipwrecks have compounded the fisherfolk's hardships," says T.J. Anjalose, state president of the All India Trade Union Congress. "They are finding more plastic than fish. The state must compensate them for the losses and press for a thorough investigation by the Directorate General of Shipping."

WHAT NOW

- Salvage op. to prevent oil spill and other hazards
- Detailed scientific studies to assess coastal pollution
- Legal action and tighter maritime safety regulations
- Compensation and long-term support for fisherfolk

The predominantly fish-eating state is also increasingly concerned about the toxic pollution washing up along its once-pristine coastlines. Dr Anu Gopinath, head of the aquatic environment management department at Kerala University of Fisheries and Ocean Studies (KUFOS) in Kochi, has warned of serious long-term consequences. "We must conduct detailed monitoring on the impact of the shipwrecks. The *Wan Hai* vessel has tonnes of inflammable and toxic substances, including pesticides, that may threaten aquatic ecosystems with far-reaching and serious consequences," she says. The Kochi-based Central Marine Fisheries Research Institute (CMFRI), initially tasked with investigating coastal pollution after the MSC *Elsa 3* wreck, has now begun collecting seawater samples near the *Wan Hai* mishap site as well to detect the presence of harmful chemicals.

As salvage crews toil against time and tide, Kerala finds itself at an inflection point. V.J. Mathew, former chairman of the Kerala Maritime Board, argues that with the Vizhinjam port expanding, the state needs a permanent maritime monitoring system and tougher legal mechanisms. "Shipping companies must be held accountable," he says. The immediate crisis will fade, as all crises do. But without urgent reforms—stricter regulations and enforcement for hazardous cargo movement and long-term ecological surveillance—Kerala's fragile marine habitats, and the lives that depend on them, may be doomed to relive these disasters, again and again. ■